Toba's personal priest—as less than ideal. "Go-Shirakawa [used to] administer state affairs," he writes in the *Gukansho*. "It was . . . now strange to have no Retired Emperor performing such functions."[9]

Finally, in 1198, Go-Toba had retired to the role of Cloistered Emperor, leaving his toddler son on the throne. This was not, in his eyes, a retreat. "Go-Toba himself wanted to abdicate," Jien says, "because he wished to conduct state affairs in his own way." As Cloistered Emperor, Go-Toba aspired to be as powerful as his grandfather Go-Shirakawa. He controlled court appointments; he approved or denied requests for promotions; he managed domestic crises; he arranged for his own young son, rather than the future heir of the reigning emperor, to become Crown Prince. His personal crest, a double flower with sixteen petals, was later adopted by the Japanese court as a symbol of the imperial right to rule; from this, the emperor's seat acquired the nickname of the Chrysanthemum Throne.[10]

Go-Toba also came increasingly to believe that the siblings Yoshitoki and Masako intended to split Japan in half: two countries, one ruled by emperor, the other by shogun. And gossip that reached him from the east led him to think that the samurai—particularly those farther west—were tired of the dominance of the Hojo, the clan of Yoshitoki and Masako. The fourteenth-century Japanese chronicle known as *The Clear Mirror*, fictionalized in places and taking poetic license in many others, nevertheless preserves the Cloistered Emperor's suspicions—and his decision to take action against the *shikken* and his allies.

> The whole realm had fallen under the sway of Yoshitoki, a man whose power all but surpassed that of Yoritomo in the old days. Naturally enough, his shocking excesses inspired secret thoughts of opposition in Retired Emperor Go-Toba's mind. The senior nobles and courtiers close to the ruler, the junior north guards, the west guards, and all the other private sympathizers with the imperial plans engaged in military pursuits day and night. . . . Meanwhile, news of Retired Emperor Go-Toba's plans leaked out in spite of every effort at secrecy, and the authorities in Kamakura . . . adopted countermeasures.[11]

With his cover blown, Go-Toba ordered his imperial retainers to attack the shogun's representative in Kyoto, an inoffensive deputy who panicked and disemboweled himself when he saw the emperor's men bearing down on him. ("The retired emperor," says *The Clear Mirror*, "considered it a good beginning.")[12]

In retaliation, Yoshitoki ordered "a mighty host, a veritable cloud of